talk, I'd no intention of ever making the move at that time and Mum knew that. What's more, she would never have wanted me to leave England: it had been bad enough me moving to Manchester, hadn't it? She couldn't help her intuition, though: she just made sure she kept it to herself. While Mum was having her moment, I was down there and grinning from ear to ear during the warm-up. You come out of the tunnel into the glare of floodlights and the din of a 75,000 crowd who demand the absolute best. If you're a player and that setting doesn't turn you on, you might as well forget it: the alternative is to get intimidated by it, in which case you'll have lost the game before you kick off.

Mum was right to sense that something significant was about to happen for her boy that night. I could pick out any number of incidents that took me down the path to what happened this past summer. My big moment at the Bernabeu wasn't anything spectacular but I think it played its part in taking me back there as a Real player. About five minutes into the game, we got a free-kick just inside the Madrid half. I took it and, just as I struck the ball forward, I felt my hamstring tighten. It didn't tear. If that had happened, I wouldn't have had any choice about what to do; I'd have come off and been laid up for the next three weeks. I'd have missed the second leg at Old Trafford, no question. In hindsight, I guess I should have given the bench a wave and made my excuses. But that's not me. It's not most players. We'd just kicked off in what felt like one of the biggest games of our lives. I was desperate to play; desperate to impress in this stadium and against these players.

It was uncomfortable but I convinced myself I'd run it off. And so I carried on.

Over the next forty minutes, Real played soccer like I'd never seen it played in my life. It wasn't that we were bad: we created scoring chances all the way through the first half and if we'd scored one early on, it might have made for a different game. I doubt it, though. When they had the ball, they were making runs off us all over the place. It might have looked like we were standing back, watching them play. I think the truth was that they were getting so many players involved every time they came forward that we found ourselves defending one man against two or three all over the field. It meant there were holes for us to play in when we had the ball but the Real players were too busy running past us to worry about what was going on behind them. That's why they're so good to watch when they have the kind of night they were having against us.